

Setting Records

Public interest and enthusiasm for setting aerial world records continued throughout the 1930s, with the Soviet Union, and European nations in particular competing to send pilots to ever greater speeds, altitudes, and distances. Some of the records set in this decade are still unbroken more than 70 years later, including the world speed record for seaplanes and the longest nonstop flight for a single-engined aircraft.



△ de Havilland DH80A
Puss Moth 1930

Origin UK

Engine 120 hp de Havilland Gipsy III
air-cooled inverted 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 128 mph (196 km/h)

This modern and rapid three-seater with enclosed cockpit, made many record attempts, notably with Jim Mollison (first solo east-west Atlantic) and his wife Amy Johnson (UK to Cape Town, and Tokyo).



△ de Havilland DH88 Comet Racer 1934

Origin UK

Engine 223 hp de Havilland Gipsy Six R air-cooled
inverted 6-cylinder in-line

Top speed 255 mph (410 km/h)

The Comet was light, fast, and built to win the 1934 MacRobertson Air Race from London, UK, to Melbourne, Australia. C. W. A. Scott and Tom Campbell Black arrived in 71 hours–19 hours ahead of the next competitor.



◁ Blériot 110 1930

Origin France

Engine 600 hp Hispano-Suiza 12L
water-cooled V12

Top speed 137 mph (220 km/h)

Built for the government, it had mirrors for takeoff and landing and carried 1,585 gallons (6,000 liters) of fuel. Its 1932 closed-circuit record was 76 hours and 34 minutes for 5,658 miles (9,106 km) and, in 1933, New York to Rayak, Syria, 6,587 miles (10,600 km).



△ Curtiss Robin J-1 1928

Origin US

Engine 165 hp Wright Whirlwind
J-6-5 radial

Top speed 110 mph (177 km/h)

Supported by inflight refueling, Dale Jackson and Forest O'Brine took the world endurance record to 17 days, 12 hours, and 17 minutes, from July 13 to 30, 1929; in 1935 Fred and Algene Key raised it to 27 days in the same aircraft type.



▷ Macchi Castoldi MC72 1931

Origin Italy

Engine 2,850 hp Fiat AS.6
supercharged water-cooled V24

Top speed 441 mph (709 km/h)

The fastest piston-engined seaplane, the tandem-engined MC72 was the holder of the outright world airspeed record for five years. Francesco Agello averaged 441 mph (710 km/h) on October 23, 1934.



▽ Franklin PS-2 Texaco Eaglet 1931

Origin US

Engine None

Top speed 125 mph (201 km/h)

Frank Hawks flew this Eaglet glider across the US from Los Angeles to New York in 1930, towed by a Waco 10 biplane and sponsored by Texaco. He attracted huge crowds at every refueling stop.

